

CSDB.GG // GUIDE

HOW CS2 RANKING WORKS: PREMIER RATING & THE SKILL GROUP SYSTEM

The complete map of CS2's ranking systems — CS Rating tiers, per-map Competitive ranks, and what it takes to climb

BEGINNER FRIENDLY

NO PRIOR CS2 KNOWLEDGE REQUIRED

TL;DR

CS2 has two ranked ladders. **Premier** shows a numeric **CS Rating** (roughly 1,000 to 30,000+, split into seven color tiers from gray to gold). **Competitive** uses the classic 18 skill groups from Silver I to The Global Elite — tracked separately on every map. Wingman has its own third set of ranks for 2v2.

Ask three CS2 players what their rank is and you might get three different kinds of answer: a five-digit number, a badge name like "Legendary Eagle," and a shrug followed by a FACEIT level. All three are legitimate, because Counter-Strike 2 runs two official ranked ladders side by side — **Premier**, with its visible CS Rating number, and **Competitive**, with the classic 18 skill groups inherited from CS:GO — while a large slice of the player base ranks itself on third-party platforms instead. This guide untangles the whole system: what each ladder measures, every tier and skill group by name, how placements and seasons work, and what actually moves your rank.

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THE TWO OFFICIAL LADDERS AT A GLANCE

The split is simple once you see what each mode is for. **Premier** is the flagship: best-of-24 (MR12) matches with a map pick-ban phase across the full Active Duty pool, ranked by a single CS Rating number with global, regional, and friends leaderboards. It's the mode Valve balances the competitive experience around, and when someone quotes a number like "18,542" as their rank, this is where it comes from.

Competitive is the traditional queue. You pick the specific map you want to play, and your result moves a skill-group badge — Silver I through The Global Elite — that exists *only for that map*. There's no veto phase and no number, just the badge. Because ranks are per-map, Competitive doubles as a low-stakes proving ground: you can learn Nuke from scratch without your Mirage standing taking the hit.

A third ladder, **Wingman**, covers 2v2 matches on cut-down maps and keeps its own separate skill groups. It shares the badge artwork with Competitive but nothing else — more on that below.

One prerequisite applies to all of them: ranked queues require Prime Status, and your rating or rank stays hidden until you've won your placement matches. If you haven't unlocked ranked play yet, our [guide to unlocking Premier](#) walks through Prime, the new-account XP gate, and the placement grind step by step.

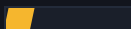
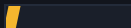
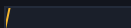
PREMIER AND CS RATING: THE NUMERIC LADDER

Premier replaces badge ranks with **CS Rating** — an Elo-style number that moves after every match. Win and it goes up; lose and it comes down; the size of the swing reflects the rating gap between the teams and how convincing the scoreline was. Ratings in the wild run from around 1,000 up past 30,000 for the very top of the leaderboards, and the number is displayed openly: on the scoreboard, on your profile, and against your name in the match-found screen.

To make the raw number readable at a glance, Valve breaks it into seven color tiers:

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THE SEVEN CS RATING TIERS, AND HOW CROWDED EACH IS

TIER	CS RATING	ESTIMATED SHARE	PERCENTILE
 Grey	0–4,999	21.2% 	Bottom 21%
 Light Blue	5,000–9,999	23.9% 	21st – 45th percentile
 Blue	10,000–14,999	26.5% 	45th – 72nd percentile
 Purple	15,000–19,999	19.9% 	72nd – 92nd percentile
 Pink	20,000–24,999	5.5% 	92nd – 97th percentile
 Red	25,000–29,999	2.4% 	Top 3%
 Gold	30,000+	0.6% 	Top 0.6%

Bands are Valve's display colours; the share column is a **community estimate** — Valve publishes no official distribution. Our figures come from Leetify match data aggregated by Esports Tales (Season 4, March 2026 snapshot) and are refreshed when the next seasonal snapshot publishes. Find your own percentile on the [CS2 rank distribution page](#).

The tiers are display bands, not gates — nothing special happens when you cross 10,000 except the color of your number. But they're useful shorthand, and the share column is the part worth staring at: the population thins out dramatically as the colors warm up, so "purple and above" is already rare company while red and gold are a rounding error of the ladder.

PLACEMENTS: WINNING YOUR FIRST TEN

A fresh account — or any account at the start of a new season — shows "Unrated" in Premier until it has banked **ten wins**. Not ten games: ten wins. Losses and draws don't advance the counter, though they still feed the hidden calibration that decides where you eventually land. Valve also limits how many placement wins you can earn per day, so even a flawless run

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Placements are the highest-leverage matches of your season, which is why the standard advice is to queue them warmed up and, ideally, with teammates you trust.

SEASONS AND THE ACTIVE DUTY POOL

Premier runs in **multi-month seasons**, not weekly cycles. **Season 5 began with the update on July 8, 2026** — the same patch that rotated **Cache** into the Active Duty map pool in place of Overpass. Pick-ban draws from the Active Duty pool, so that rotation is the one patch note that changes what you actually queue into:

CURRENT MAP POOL

ACTIVE DUTY — 7 MAPS

MIRAGE

INFERNO

DUST 2

ANUBIS

ANCIENT

NUKE

CACHE

RESERVE — STILL PLAYABLE IN COMPETITIVE

OVERPASS

VERTIGO

TRAIN

The Active Duty pool is what Premier's pick-ban phase draws from. Rendered from CSDB's map database on every build — full callouts, layouts and strategy for each map on the [CS2 maps hub](#).

At each season rollover your rating is pulled toward the middle rather than wiped, and you re-run a shortened placement phase to confirm where you belong. In practice, established players land close to where they finished; the reset mainly re-sorts the boundaries and gives climbers a clean runway. Between resets there is no scheduled decay drama — your number simply sits where your last match left it.

COMPETITIVE: ALL 18 SKILL GROUPS

Competitive mode keeps the badge system that veterans know from CS:GO — the same 18 skill groups, the same artwork, the same folklore about which one counts as "actually good."

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- **Master Guardian:** **Master Guardian I**, Master Guardian II, Master Guardian Elite, Distinguished Master Guardian (DMG)
- **Elite tier:** **Legendary Eagle**, Legendary Eagle Master (LEM), Supreme Master First Class (SMFC), **The Global Elite**

The names are historical artifacts more than a tidy hierarchy — there is no official "Bronze," and "Supreme" is a single rank (SMFC), not a division. Community shorthand groups them into four broad bands, and knowing what play actually looks like in each is more useful than the badge art:

Silver (six ranks) is where everyone starts and where the fundamentals live. Games are chaotic in an endearing way — economies are improvised, smokes land somewhere near their target, and rounds are decided by raw aim duels more than strategy. The fastest way out is unglamorous: crosshair placement at head height, counter-strafting before you shoot, and learning the layout of one map properly. If that's where you are, our **beginner's guide** covers the whole foundation.

Gold Nova (four ranks) is the great middle of the ladder, where most active Competitive players spend most of their time. Mechanics are respectable; what separates Novas from the tier above is decision-making — buying as a team, rotating on information instead of noise, and using utility with a plan rather than out of habit.

Master Guardian through DMG (four ranks) is where CS2 starts looking like the game the pros play. Players hold angles properly, trade kills deliberately, and punish dry pushes with utility. Progress here comes from studying your own play — recurring positioning mistakes, wasted grenades, mistimed aggression — rather than from grinding more hours of deathmatch.

Legendary Eagle to The Global Elite (four ranks) is the sharp end. Lobbies are full of players with thousands of hours, mid-round calling is expected, and individual mistakes get punished immediately. Players at this level usually split their time with FACEIT, where the queue quality at high skill is more consistent.

BEYOND RANKS: THE BIG PICTURE

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and you're unranked there, regardless of the Mirage badge. Each map's rank moves only with results on that map.

This sounds bureaucratic but it's genuinely player-friendly. In CS:GO, learning a new map meant risking your one precious rank; in CS2 you can be a DMG on your comfort picks and a Gold Nova on the map you're learning, and neither number contaminates the other. It also means "What's your Competitive rank?" has no single answer — the honest reply is a list. If you're picking a map to calibrate on first, start with the ones whose **callouts and layouts** you already know cold.

/ HOW RANKING UP ACTUALLY WORKS

Both ladders run on the same underlying logic: an Elo-style rating adjusted after every match. The details worth knowing:

- **Wins are the engine.** Match outcome is overwhelmingly what moves your rating. A 30-bomb in a loss is still a loss; a quiet game in a win still pays. Systems that reward winning reward playing for the round, not the highlight reel.
- **Opposition quality sets the stakes.** Beating a higher-rated lobby moves your number further than farming an even one, and losing to a lower-rated lobby costs more than a coin-flip defeat.
- **Margins matter in Premier.** A 13-2 scoreline and a 13-11 overtime scrap are not treated identically — convincing wins move the needle more, which is one reason closing out matches cleanly is worth sweating.
- **Calibration is front-loaded.** Early placement results swing your eventual number hardest, in both Premier and per-map Competitive. The system wants to find your level fast and then settle into small adjustments.
- **There is no fixed win count per rank.** Nobody can tell you "five more wins to Legendary Eagle," because rank thresholds are internal and the size of each gain depends on who you beat. Sustained positive win rate against your own level is the only reliable climb.

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WHERE DO YOU ACTUALLY STAND?

Every ranked player eventually asks the same question: is my number good? Valve doesn't publish official distribution tables, which is why the share column in the tier table above is labelled an estimate rather than a fact — it comes from third-party match data, and anyone quoting a rank percentage without saying where it came from is guessing. What the available data consistently shows is the shape: the ladder is bottom-heavy, the middle bands (light blue and blue in Premier, Gold Nova in Competitive) hold the bulk of active players, and each tier above them shrinks sharply.

Rather than quote numbers that drift month to month, we keep the live picture in one place: the [rank distribution page](#) shows the current Premier rating spread, percentile bands, and the Competitive skill-group breakdown, and it's updated as the data moves. Punch in your rating there and you get an honest percentile instead of a forum guess.

PREMIER VS COMPETITIVE VS FACEIT

Third-party matchmaking is big enough in Counter-Strike that any honest ranking guide has to cover it. [FACEIT](#) runs its own ladder — ten levels backed by a visible ELO number — with its own anti-cheat and a player pool that skews toward the serious end. The three systems answer different questions:

	PREMIER	COMPETITIVE	FACEIT
Rank format	CS Rating number, 7 color tiers	18 skill groups, per map	Levels 1–10 + I
Map selection	Pick-ban across Active Duty	You choose the map	Veto, wider pool
Scope of rank	One rating, all maps	Separate rank per map	One ELO, all maps
Player pool	Largest, all skill levels	Large, casual-friendly	Smaller, improvement-focused

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The ladders don't convert cleanly into each other — a mid-level FACEIT player often carries a Premier rating that sounds impressive at first hearing, because the populations overlap but don't match. Our [FACEIT ranks page](#) breaks down the levels, the ELO thresholds, and how they roughly line up against CS Rating.

AND WINGMAN?

Wingman's 2v2 ranks reuse the Competitive badge art but live on an entirely separate track: only Wingman matches move them, and they influence nothing outside the mode. Because the format is smaller and the rating math more forgiving, most players find their Wingman badge sits a couple of groups above their Competitive one — take it as a fun side ladder, not a skill certificate.

/ FIVE RANK MYTHS WORTH KILLING

Ranking systems attract folklore, and CS2's inherited a decade of it from CS:GO. The claims below circulate constantly and are all wrong:

- **"Premier resets every week."** It doesn't. Premier seasons run for months — Season 4 spanned the first half of 2026 before Season 5 took over in July — and even the seasonal change is a soft re-calibration, not a wipe.
- **"There's a Bronze rank."** There has never been a Bronze skill group in Counter-Strike matchmaking. The ladder starts at Silver I; anyone selling you a "Bronze to Silver" guide is describing a different game.
- **"Kills decide your rating."** Winning decides your rating. Individual performance has at most a marginal influence around the edges — the player who bottom-frags in ten straight wins climbs, and the star of ten straight losses falls. Play for rounds.
- **"You can calculate exactly when you'll rank up."** Skill-group thresholds and the precise rating formula are internal to Valve and have never been published. Every "X wins per rank" table you see online is invented.
- **"Your teammates' ranks drag yours down."** Queueing with lower-rated friends changes

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CLIMBING: WHAT ACTUALLY MOVES YOUR RANK

Since wins are the engine, everything below is in service of one goal — raising your win rate a few points and holding it there.

SHRINK YOUR MAP POOL

Depth beats breadth at every level below the leaderboards. Two or three maps where you know every default smoke, common angle, and retake pattern will win you more Premier vetoes — and more rounds — than passable familiarity with the whole Active Duty pool. Competitive's per-map ranks make this explicit: your best map is measurably ranks better than your worst.

FIX THE FREE LOSSES FIRST

At most ratings, matches are lost more than they are won: eco rounds thrown by impatient buys, man-advantage rounds lost to bad trades, info deaths that hand over the round for nothing. Tightening **your economy discipline** and dying with intent costs zero mechanical talent and pays immediately.

MAKE YOUR PRACTICE DELIBERATE

Fifteen minutes of warm-up before queueing beats an hour of tilted "one more game" after losses. Keep it boring and consistent: deathmatch for raw aim, a **crosshair you don't fiddle with**, and spray control until the first ten bullets of your rifle are automatic.

REVIEW, DON'T VENT

After a bad session the useful move is opening the demo, not the queue. **Reviewing your own demos** shows the deaths that felt unlucky in the moment and look avoidable on replay — the same three or four positioning mistakes usually account for most of them.

QUEUE WITH THE SAME PEOPLE

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PROTECT YOUR PLACEMENTS

Season rollovers concentrate a season's worth of rating movement into a handful of matches. Treat re-placement games like finals: warmed up, on your best maps where the veto allows, with your regular teammates. A sloppy calibration run can cost weeks of grinding to correct.

Related Guides & Tools:

[ALL CS2 RANKS](#)[FACEIT RANKS & ELO](#)[HOW TO UNLOCK PREMIER](#)[BEGINNER'S GUIDE](#)[ECONOMY GUIDE](#)[DEMO REVIEW GUIDE](#)[MAP CALLOUTS](#)[ALL GUIDES](#)

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

WHAT ARE ALL 18 CS2 COMPETITIVE RANKS IN ORDER?

From lowest to highest: Silver I, Silver II, Silver III, Silver IV, Silver Elite, Silver Elite Master, Gold Nova I, Gold Nova II, Gold Nova III, Gold Nova Master, Master Guardian I, Master Guardian II, Master Guardian Elite, Distinguished Master Guardian, Legendary Eagle, Legendary Eagle Master, Supreme Master First Class, and The Global Elite. These are the same 18 skill groups carried over from CS:GO, but in CS2 they are tracked separately on each map.

WHAT IS THE HIGHEST RANK IN CS2?

In Competitive mode it is The Global Elite, the top of the 18 skill groups. In Premier there is no rank cap — CS Rating is an open-ended number, and the gold/yellow display tier starts at 30,000, a bracket occupied almost exclusively by leaderboard-level players.

DOES YOUR CS2 PREMIER RATING RESET EVERY SEASON?

Not from zero. Premier runs multi-month seasons — Season 5 began with the update on July 8, 2026 — and at each rollover your rating is soft-reset and you play fresh placement matches to re-calibrate. Your previous season's level still informs where the system expects you to land, so an established player does not restart alongside genuine newcomers.

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map they rarely queue. Premier, by contrast, gives you one CS Rating across the whole Active Duty pool.

HOW MANY WINS DO YOU NEED TO GET A CS2 RANK?

Ten wins in Premier before your CS Rating appears — losses and draws do not count toward the ten, and Valve caps how many placement wins you can bank per day, so calibration stretches across several sessions. Competitive also requires ten wins on a given map before that map's skill group is shown.

ARE WINGMAN RANKS CONNECTED TO PREMIER OR COMPETITIVE?

No. Wingman, the 2v2 mode, keeps its own set of skill groups earned only through Wingman matches. Your Wingman badge has no effect on your Premier CS Rating or your per-map Competitive ranks, which is why it often sits a few groups higher — the smaller format tends to be rated more generously.

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